long-pending Lok Pal Bill that provided for the setting up of an anti-corruption ombudsman. The initial response was lukewarm. Very few in the national media were really aware of Hazare and his politics. He had spent most of his life in Maharashtra, taking on ministers accused of corruption, and had built a formidable reputation as an untiring crusader for public causes. At least three state ministers had been forced to resign because of his efforts. But in Delhi, the Gandhi topi of Hazare seemed like a museum piece from another era—he was seen as little more than a temporary distraction, just one of the many activists who populated Jantar Mantar through the year.

When Hazare began his fast on 5 April the story was just another headline. That day, Anna spoke out against the Union agriculture minister and Maharashtra strongman Sharad Pawar, questioning his credentials to be part of the group of ministers appointed to review the draft Lok Pal Bill. The attack on Pawar was sharp and hit home—the next day, Pawar resigned from the committee. Suddenly, the national media sat up and took note. Hazare was now a front-page story being played out across television channels. A fast which had begun with a few hundred supporters was now gaining momentum. Within seventy-two hours, it would strike a huge chord across the country.

I was at Jantar Mantar watching with amazement as the crowds kept growing. My teenage son Ishan had gone with his class friends on a Yamuna yatra to Uttarakhand. Suddenly, I spotted him at Jantar Mantar with schoolmates. ‘We’ve come here to express our solidarity with Anna,’ he said enthusiastically. He was not alone. A majority of the audience were middle-class Indians—government employees, housewives, shopkeepers, traders, all of whom had a story to tell about how corruption was affecting their lives. *‘Annaji sahi kar rahe hain, woh hamari ladai lad rahe hai’* (Anna is doing the right thing, he is fighting our fight), was the overwhelming sentiment. Even one of the local policemen who had been charged with providing security for Hazare admitted quietly, *‘Bande mein hai dum!’* (This man is strong.) Shades of Gandhi emanated subliminally from the image of Anna. A few years earlier the Bollywood hit *Lage Raho*